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The House of Small Cubes, (2008). Director Kunio Katô

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Instructor: Yuen May Chan

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ANIMATION OF CHOICE



The House of Small Cubes, (2008). Director Kunio Katô. Animated short film, drama.

INTRODUCTION

The animation, *house of small cubes*, is a 12 minutes Japanese drama animated short film and directed by Kunio Katô. It was released in 2008 and won the Academic Short Award for Best Animated Short Film in 2009. The story is about a lonely old man, who lives alone in an isolated house. With the rising of sea level, the old man build his house, made of cube-shaped blocks. While building the house, the pipe he cherishes drops into water and he has to dive to seek for it. As he continues to sink, his memories of the past keeps emerging and he dives deeper to find the valuable memories. Finally, he feels released and enjoys his life. In conclusion, through its unique narrative structure and beautiful hand-drawn style, the film focuses on the profound theme of environment, time, memory and emotion.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

From the aspect of societal background, it implies environmental change and aging society. Especially global warming, it threatens the survival of islanders and the film indicates the process from helplessness to adaptation. Furthermore, the film expresses the Japanese concept of “mono no aware”, finds wistful beauty in the transient, and is most often translated to ‘beauty in pathos’ (Ward, 2022). It can be defined as "to see and hear things in contact with heartfelt sigh" (Dong, 2016). Thus, it is reflected in the nostalgic emotion, slight sadness to passage of time. From the perspective of technology, contrasting with many digitally produced animations, the film utilizes traditional hand-drawn animation techniques and digital technology for post-production, creating a delicate and emotional visual effect. according to *A New*

History of Animation, instead of creating something cute, this animation combines French romantic style and profound emotional expression. It is achieved through hand-drawn storyboards, line drawing, digital coloring, watercolor backgrounds, frame-by-frame animation and digital production. In brief, its profound thought and combination of traditional hand-drawn style and modern digital tools make a significant difference in the history of animation.

KEY DEVELOPMENTS AND WORKS

This animation takes place in a world that is slowly being submerged by water. With the rising of sea level, the memories accumulate and are swallowed by the water. The film involves minimalism, abstract art and especially unique hand-drawn style with watercolor-like textures. It features smooth camera movements and a slow visual rhythm. The main character is an elderly man who lives alone in a house, composed of small cubes and situated in the flooded landscape. He has lowered head, hunched back, red and green clothes, stocky build and round body. His face droops with lots of wrinkles, which highlights his advanced age and life experiences. The story begins with the elderly man realizing that the water has risen again, compelling him to build another layer on the top of his house. When he accidentally drops his pipe into the water, he dives to find it, reminiscing about memories with his family. Finally, he fetches a goblet and toasts alone. The last scene depicts a lonely old man who feels relieved, enjoys life, and misses the past moment.

GLOBAL WARMING

The recurring motif of rising water levels is a strong visual representation of global warming. Plus, the continuous construction of new layers of his house symbolizes human's effort to adapt to the environmental condition, without addressing the root cause of the problem. The houses and stuff, submerged by seawater, reflect the irreversible loss of history, culture and memories. With the booming of environmental issues, human may suffer from the limited living space and other problems that threaten the survival of human. Actually, the setting emphasizes a sense of isolation and loss, showcasing the potential future of human conditions. Eventually, it successfully arouses the thorough reflection for global warming.



Fig 1: the water floods into his house

THE AGING SOCIETY

In one of the memory clips, his daughter waves him goodbye and leaves for the outside world, directly implying the fact that children leave original place to seek for fortune in the big cities. The gradually shrinking house and repetitive building routine can be interpreted as a symbol of the marginalization of the elderly in society. Besides,

the film uses muted colors and dim lighting to create a reflective atmosphere, suggesting melancholy or loneliness. With fewer family members around him who share their memories, the old may feel isolated and forgotten, which can be seen and felt in this animation. Furthermore, it deeply explores the emotions without outspoken dialogue and makes a deep impression in audience' heart. Overall, the film successfully conveys the sense of loneliness and nostalgia in an aging society through its unique visual style, narrative structure and profound emotional expression.

LONELINESS AND MEMORY

At the beginning, the old man sees the pictures, put on the wall, showing his longing for family. Also, the old man's search for his pipe is not only a pursuit of personal memories but also a longing for family and affection, reflecting the importance of close relationships in an aging society.



Fig. 2: the lonely old man looks at the pictures

From the aspect of composition, it uses large amount of establishing shot to demonstrate the isolated house, highlighting the elderly man's extreme loneliness and desire for family and company.



Fig. 3: a establishing shot in the film

For the character design, with little eyes and bent back, he looks into the distance through window, adding more sense of vicissitudes.

From the perspective of color, the muted and subdued color scheme enhances the theme of loneliness, except for the red shirt, green pants, green TV and red table cloth, which add more warmth in the monotonous scene. However, the colorful things, indicating his positive attitude towards life, make a high contrast to the surroundings and further highlight the sense of loneliness. The whole screen seems to be covered in a layer of gray. But the warm yellow scene with light makes a high contrast to the blue seawater, brightens audience's eyes and lightens the old man's flame in his heart.

Also, one of the most important features are the music and sound, which guide audience to interpret the elderly man's thoughts and emotions, and distinguish the memories' clips and reality.

Table 1: emotions in the music and sound

Duration	Description	Analysis/Interpretation
01:42 – 01:53	Laughter in the TV	Establishing shot with dim lighting from TV and light bulb exaggerates his loneliness.
02:13 – 02:38	The background music changes from peaceful pace to a pause last to fall tune	The music can be interpreted as - the old man is used to the flood, misses his wife who used to build the house with him, and feels upset and lonely at last.
06:28 - 06:42	The upbeat music and sound of shutter	With warm and yellow light, the music implies the quickly passage of precious time. And the scene changes suddenly with the man cannot pulling his thoughts out.
04:05 - 04:18	Pipe drops with a plop, gurgling sound of sinking in water, a sigh of the old man	The sound changes with different visual angle, from the third to the first of the man and then to the third perspective, showing his worry and concern of the pipe, which is the only lasting “companion” and carries his missing to the past.

Furthermore, the camera movement can not only guide audience’s attention, but show the environment and old man’s POV to convey the feelings of the man.

Table 2: Important camera movement in the film

Duration	Description	Analysis/Interpretation
08: 30– 08:52	The man’s POV - camera pan up; The man looks to the left - POV - pan left to - transition from reality to the memory	Make a smooth transition to the past and let audience see what he sees, think what he thinks, skillfully conveying a faint sadness.

03: 17–03:25	The camera zoom out or pull out	Establishing shot and overhead level. With the old man building the new layer of the house, he gradually becomes a red dot in the screen, showing his tiny and isolated situation.

Besides, the film uses lots of dissolve to make a transition and emphasize his irrepressible nostalgia. In conclusion, this film successfully let audience understand the man's emotions and thoughts through music, sound, color, camera movement etc.

IMPACT

The hand-drawn and water-like style, distinguished from the computer-generated animation, is appealing to audience and makes them immersed in the lonely and slow-paced world. The film demonstrates that traditional techniques can be powerful in conveying feelings and thoughts, encouraging a return to handcrafted visual styles.

Besides, the film breaks the cultural barriers and stereotype in Japanese animation, exposing the global issues, such as global warming and aging society. Without dialogue, it expresses complex emotions and themes through sound, music, behavior, camera movement etc. Especially for its evocatively affecting music and sound, the film changes the pace of the music to represent and render the inner emotions, which can be understood by all people.

Moreover, the film serves as both a work of art and a quiet call to awareness about the global warming and aging society, evoking the empathy for the old and the reflection about human's harmful behavior to the environment.

Furthermore, the non-linear narrative structure is outstanding and extraordinary. It uses visual effect to compensate for the loss of dialogue and skillfully interweave the past and reality. For instance, the warm yellow hue and soft, slightly happy music, distinguished from the reality, indicate the precious and happy memories and make narration easier and clearer. Plus, this film uses the prop, pipe, to drive the development of plot, which is commonly used in film scripts.

Last but not least, the small cubes represents passage of time, memories and episodes of life, inspiring animators to simplify abstract thoughts into visual representations. During a conversation with Manga-News, Katô said, “These stacked cubes were, for me, the symbol of life, each one representing one more memory, which comes to accumulate for others. Subsequently, I realized that this is a fairly recurrent theme in my works, but also in the next ones that I will do. I really like everything that can symbolize a life” (Bose, 2023).

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, his essay explores the history context, key developments and impact on the realm of animation. The film masterfully combines the themes of global warming, aging society, loneliness and memories, through dynamic music, synchronous sound, non-linear narrative structure, motifs, important props etc. More importantly, this animation inspires artists that traditional technique matters and silence films can break cultural barriers and stand out. Overall, “ The House of Small Cubes” is worth appreciating and learning.

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APPENDICES

Appendix A: Background, music and sound...

